



is part of its appeal. Expedition journeys typically start at about ₹15 lakh per person and can rise significantly depending on the route, ship, and level of exclusivity. Add another ₹3.5 lakh per person for airfare to Argentina or Chile from where these journeys typically start. Because sailing windows are limited and ships carry relatively few passengers, these journeys are usually booked nine to twelve months in advance. The best time to visit Antarctica is from November to March.

The experience itself is expedition-based rather than cruise-based in the traditional sense. Travellers cross the Drake Passage, explore ice forma-

tions by Zodiac boats, land on ice sheets, watch penguin colonies and whales, and attend lectures by scientists and expedition leaders. Activities can include kayaking among icebergs, hiking across polar terrain and even the traditional polar plunge into freezing waters, made extremely popular on social media.

Some operators, such as Thomas Cook, combine Antarctic expeditions with stays in cities such as Buenos Aires or Rio de Janeiro.

EMERGING POLAR MARKET

Expedition companies are increasingly recognising India as an important emerging market. According to Quark Expeditions,

one of the world's leading polar expedition operators, India has shown significant growth over the past 12 to 18 months. Travellers range from young professionals to multi-generational families, as well as Indians living abroad.

What is particularly interesting is how Indian travellers approach polar travel differently. Many prefer cabins with balconies, value food options including vegetarian and vegan meals, and often travel in groups or family clusters. There has also been a noticeable shift from fly-cruise expeditions to full sailing expeditions, particularly across the 800-km Drake Passage.

According to Tenille Hunt, Regional Director APAC for Quark